Generative AI: Hopes, Controversies and the Future of Faculty Roles in Education

Abstract

Generative artificial intelligence (GAI) has seen exponential growth in recent years due to its capability to generate original content through natural language processing and comprehensive language models. This paper aims to investigate the transformative impact of GAI on higher education, focusing on the evolving roles of faculty in the classroom. Using a phenomenological perspective and a process approach, the study involved 40 semi-structured interviews with academicians in higher education. The findings reveal that GAI currently creates biased and commercially driven learning environments, challenging traditional pedagogical models. Despite its potential for enhancing education, the autonomous nature of GAI often prioritizes commercial interests over pedagogical goals. The study is limited to faculty perspectives, suggesting future research should include student viewpoints and diverse educational contexts. The study highlights the need for higher education institutions to develop comprehensive policies, provide training for faculty and students and design new courses that leverage GAI for personalized learning experiences and enhanced faculty research. This paper contributes to the emerging literature on GAI's impact on education, highlighting its dual nature as both a transformative tool and a potential threat to traditional educational roles and outcomes.